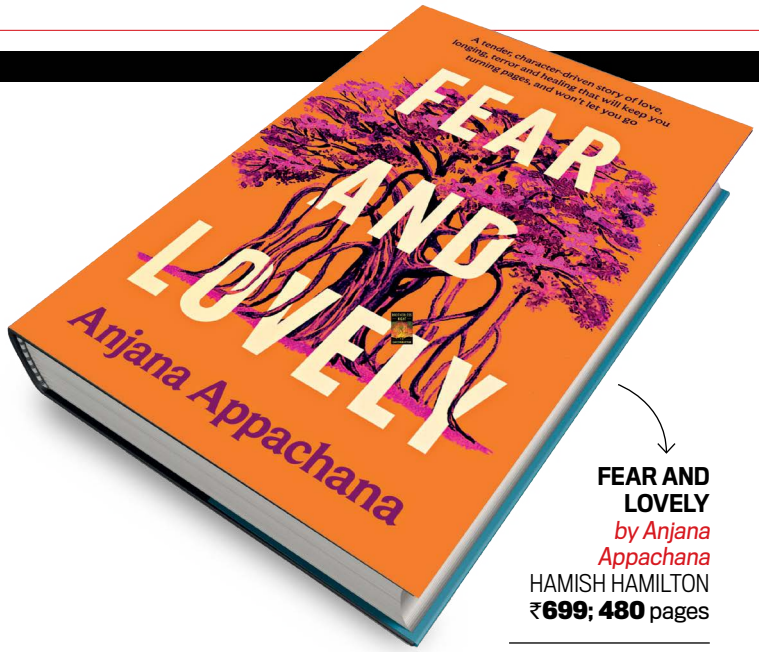
BOOKS

NOT A FOREIGN COUNTRY

The past, in Anjana Appachana's novel, is brought to pulsating life as an ensemble cast of characters grapple with existence in Emergency-era Delhi



FEAR AND LOVELY
by Anjana Appachana
HAMISH HAMILTON
₹699; 480 pages

ANJANA APPACHANA IS a wonderfully understated and charming writer. Long ago, when I was a junior editor, I was given her first novel *Listening Now* (1998) to review. I read the book with breathless excitement, then discovered to my horror that the book lacked a crucial 50 pages containing the denouement. We wrote to the publishers pointing this out, but heard nothing back. The person who sent me the book for review told me rather ruefully that the publishers seemed surprised that a reviewer had actually read it. Ah, the heady days of liberalisation. The review fell through, and to this day I don't know what happened in the end. Which is a great pity, because the book was a corker.

This novel is different in that it has a wide ensemble cast and a more subtle structure. Appachana's chosen matter is that enchanting era of the past when it was ten rupees to the dollar and everyone watched the same TV channel. Delhi at the time of the Emergency is both scary and reassuring: families can talk politics at the dinner table without coming to blows, and young people have an innocent ardour for the future that fills you with tender terror for them.

Her main character in *Fear and Lovely*, the enigmatic and charming Mallika, blessed with two mothers and half a father, is utterly believable. She tells Mallika's story through a braid of interweaving points of view that go over the same incidents multiple times like gossiping aunties, making you feel like you should be thoroughly dizzy, but you are only exhilarated, as if you were on a roller-coaster at a suburban fair.

Appachana foreshadows the conclusion (and the big revelation) repeatedly, but this in no way diminishes the shock and wonder of the final denouement. Although her plotting is flawless, her aim is not to create suspense, or rather, the suspense is emotional and affective rather than cerebral. She gently unfolds how the characters felt in those moments, how they experienced each other, dealt with their pain, came to terms with their failures, how they loved.

> **Appachana gently unfolds how the characters felt, experienced each other, dealt with pain, came to terms with failures and how they loved**

It all comes down to three significant days of Mallika's life that she has forgotten, apparently as a result of head trauma, but you can't help wondering whether the wound she suffered is of an entirely different nature, and you both dread and wish for the truth.

Although the story is set in the adolescent times of people in their sixties today, it is a thoroughly contemporary book, and could be read with profit by young people who want to know what makes their elders tick. Jaded as we are by the empty rhetoric of *achhe din*, it is salutary to be reminded of what the *bure din* of the past were like. This is a lovely book to read if you want a warm nostalgia bath at the end of a particularly postmodern day. ■

Rimi B. Chatterjee